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The material below provides information about alcohol and your health.
Use this to help answer questions you might have about alcohol.

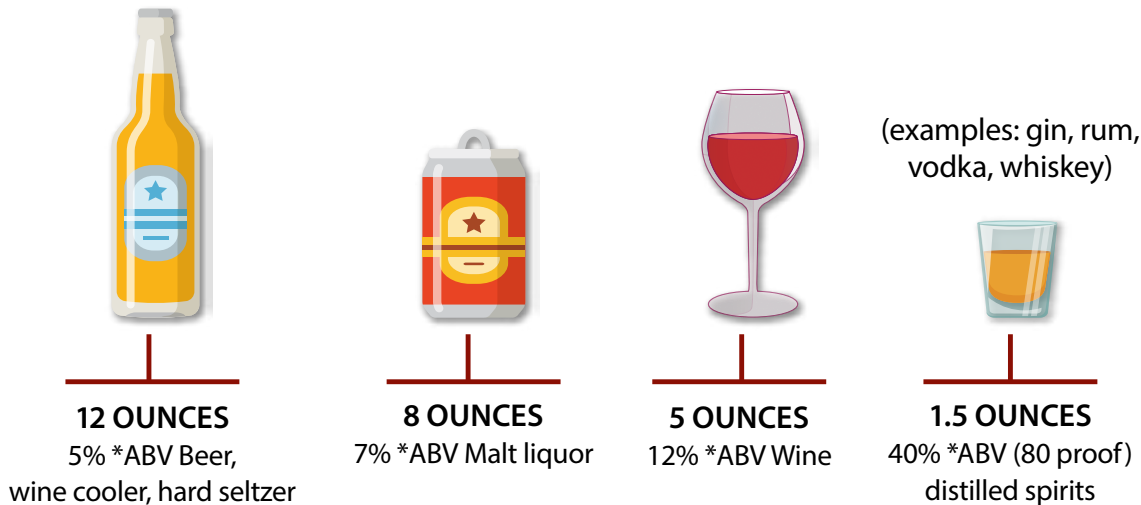
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Alcohol Use and Your Health

During times of stress or isolation, such as during the COVID-19 pandemic, many people turn to alcohol to cope. This could lead to drinking more than may be healthy or safe.

Drinking too much can harm your body and affect your overall health. If you consume alcohol, it is important to know your risks. Below is information that can help you understand if your health is at risk.

What counts as ONE drink?



*ABV = Alcohol by Volume

What is considered moderate drinking?



To reduce the risks associated with alcohol it is recommended that you drink in moderation. Moderate levels are about one drink a day for women and one to two drinks a day for men. You can also choose not to drink.

If you choose to drink alcohol, be safe! Your health risks are less if you stay within the daily or weekly recommended limits. Anything over the recommended daily and weekly limits is considered heavy drinking.

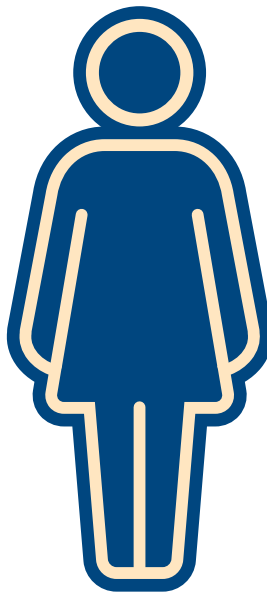
You Are a Heavy Drinker if...

you are a

female

who drinks

8



or a heavy
drinking day
which is more
than 3 drinks



+

a day

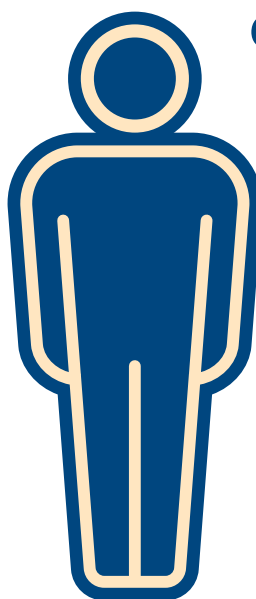
or more drinks
in 1 week

you are a

male

who drinks

15



or a heavy
drinking day
which is
more than
4 drinks



+



a day

or more
drinks
in 1 week

Heavy drinking can put you at risk for the following:

Increased cancer risk ■ Breast ■ Mouth ■ Throat ■ Liver ■ Colon 	More risk for infections ■ Frequent colds ■ Higher risk of pneumonia or lung infections 	May increase or worsen mental health issues ■ Anxiety ■ Depression ■ Insomnia or sleep issues 
Increased risk for chronic diseases ■ High blood pressure ■ Heart disease ■ Stroke ■ Liver disease ■ Painful nerves (numbness and tingling) 	May have trouble with learning and memory ■ Memory loss ■ Dementia ■ Poor school or work performance 	Increased stomach and digestive issues ■ Stomach problems ■ Heartburn ■ Vitamin deficiencies ■ Bleeding ■ Ulcers ■ Malnutrition 
Increased reproductive problems ■ Male: Impaired sexual performance ■ Female: Decreased fertility; risk of birth defects		Increased social, legal, medical, domestic, job, and financial issues

Drinking over the daily and weekly limits can also increase the risk of developing alcohol use disorder.

Look at the list below and see if anything sounds familiar?

- ☐ When I drink, I set limits but cannot stick with them.
- ☐ I would like to cut down or stop drinking. I have tried to control my alcohol use but have not been able to reduce it.
- ☐ I spend a lot of my time drinking or recovering from hangovers.
- ☐ I have a strong urge or desire to drink alcohol.
- ☐ I have given up or cut back on things I enjoy so that I can drink or recover from drinking alcohol.
- ☐ I continue to drink alcohol despite the problems it is causing with my relationship with family or friends.
- ☐ Drinking makes it hard for me to take care of my home, family or has resulted in job or school troubles.

- ☐ I continue to drink alcohol despite it worsening my health problems.
- ☐ I must drink more to get the effect I want or the effect that I used to have in the past.
- ☐ I use alcohol and then engage in activities like driving, swimming, or unsafe sex. Using alcohol while doing these activities could put me or others at increased physical risk.
- ☐ I feel shaky, anxious, and/or sweaty when the alcohol wears off.

Did you check any of the boxes?

If so, this could mean that your drinking has become problematic. If this is the case, you can take steps to reduce your risk. Remember that small changes can make a big difference. See the next page for ideas around cutting back on drinking.

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If you have a hard time cutting down, talk to your provider about your concerns. Together you can form a plan to help you cut down or stop drinking altogether.

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Stopping alcohol can cause alcohol withdrawal and it could be fatal. If you have had withdrawal symptoms in the past, work with your medical provider to develop a plan.

Below are common alcohol withdrawal symptoms:

- Whole body: shakiness, sweating, or loss of appetite
- Behavioral: agitation, restlessness, or irritability
- Gastrointestinal: nausea or vomiting
- Mood: anxiety or nervousness
- Also common: fast heart rate, tremor, disorientation, headache, insomnia, or seizures